BEYOND EVALUATION USE

An Empirical Study of Involvement and Use/Influence in Multi-Site Evaluations

Training Facilitator's Guide

Planning for use serves as the cornerstone of good evaluation practice. Developed from five years of research on participation in and use of evaluation in multi-site settings, this trainers' guide identifies critical steps an evaluator can take to plan for and facilitate involvement and use in multi-site evaluations.

This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. REC 0438545. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation

This guide is one part of a training package that has been developed and refined through use at three national evaluation conferences. It is suitable for use for personal instruction or as a starting point for facilitating a workshop on *planning for use in multi-site evaluations*. Use of any of these materials within a training session where participants have been charged a fee is prohibited.

All materials described below that comprise this training package are available online at the Beyond Evaluation Use Research Project Website (http://www.cehd.umn.edu/projects/beu/default.html).

The Making the Most Trainers' Toolkit Components:

1. Full video of the Making the Most of Multi-site Evaluation Workshop The session was recorded at the Centers for Disease Control/American Evaluation Association Evaluation Institute (June, 2009) by the University of Minnesota research team led by Dr. Frances Lawrenz & Dr. Jean A. King.

2. Comprehensive Guide (pdf)
   This guide contains ALL of the components noted below in the next section in a single, downloadable format.

3. PowerPoint Presentation (pdf or ppt)
   The PowerPoint presentation with facilitator notes can be used as is or adapted for your workshop context. This is available in two versions:
   - *PowerPoint as pdf document: The pdf version includes full notes and is good for initial review and self-study*
   - *PowerPoint as ppt document: The PowerPoint version may be manipulated to show both notes and slides and customized for your own presentations.*

Components included in the Comprehensive Guide:

a. Facilitator's Guide (pdf): Read this first for an overview of the components of the training package and for useful information on preparing for and conducting a training workshop.
b. Making the Most of Multi-site Evaluations Checklist (pdf): The work sheet is to be used by participants during the small group exercise.
c. Voicing Variables Instructions (pdf): The handout is only for the facilitator as a guide for conducting the Voicing Variables activity at the beginning of the training session.
d. Three Step Interview Instructions and Participant Handout (pdf): The handout provides the facilitator with directions for facilitating the Three-Step Interview Activity that frames the session and provides participants and the trainer a chance to learn about each others' skill level and experience with multi-site evaluation. In addition, the participant handout is provided to each group of three for note-taking during the activity.
e. The Presentation References: For those who may want to read more after the session about the topics introduced in this session, references are included and may be distributed.
f. Workshop Evaluation Form (pdf): This optional form can be used to have participants evaluate your workshop.

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Slide 1



Note to the presenter:

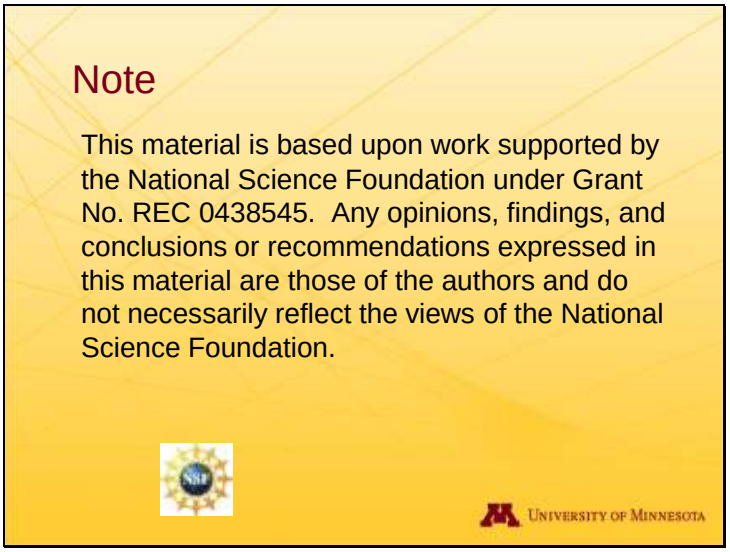
- Edit the title screen of this slide to reflect your session location and date

As the session begins:

- Introduce the session and the presenter(s).
- Lead participants in the Voicing Variables Activity (see Training Comprehensive Guide for complete instructions).

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Slide 2



Note to the presenter:
This disclaimer does not need to be read aloud, but it should be somewhere in the presentation. This statement acknowledges the funding by NSF and provides the audience with the grant number. We have placed it as the second slide, but it could easily be the first and be up while people are getting settled. Then, when you are ready to begin just start at the title slide.

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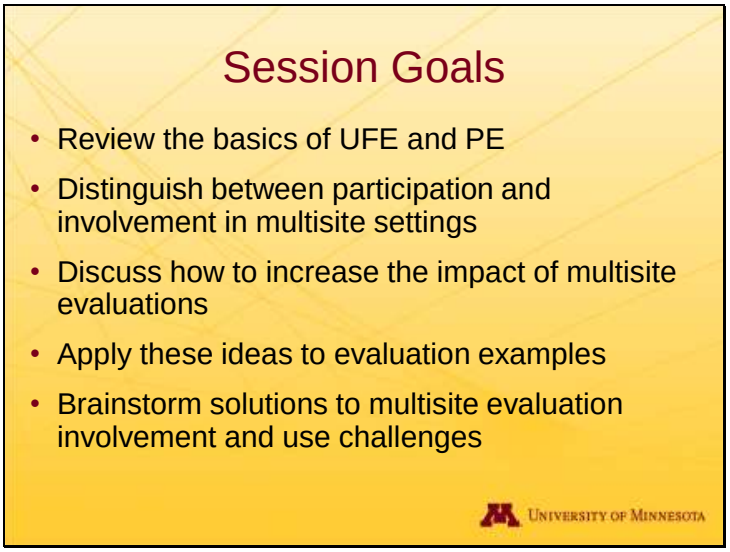
Slide 3



Note to the presenter:
Review the agenda with your participants

To the audience:
This research was done to examine some well-known frameworks in evaluation to see how the ideas held up or required changes in a multi-site evaluation context. The findings have implications for practice that may improve the processes or outcomes of evaluation done in multi-site settings. We hope that this session will help you apply what you learn today to your multisite evaluations.

Slide 4



Notes to the presenter:
UFE stands for utilization-focused evaluation (work of M. Q. Patton)
PE stands for participatory evaluation

To the audience:
To get started we will first review the principles of utilization-focused evaluation and participatory evaluation, specifically explaining how traditional notions of participation have morphed in the multisite settings into something more like involvement.

Next we will discuss the ways in which the impact of a multisite evaluation may be increased and then apply all of the ideas to some examples we have created. Finally, we will brainstorm solutions to some challenges that we all may have faced in our work with multisite evaluations.

Slide 5



Notes to the presenter:
Set the stage for the Three-Step Interview activity (complete instructions and necessary documents for this activity are in the Training Comprehensive Guide). You can also see this activity in the workshop video found at http://www.cehd.umn.edu/projects/beu/default.html .

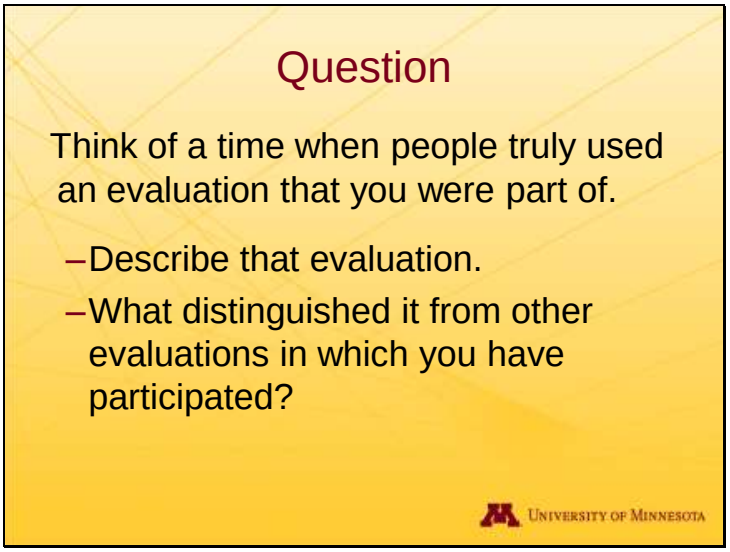
- Ask participants to organize into groups of three for the activity and have them introduce themselves to their group mates.
- Ask members of each group to count off…"I'm 1" – "I'm 2" – "I'm 3."
- Members do this because this activity will involve 3 rounds of small "interviews" where each group member assumes a different role for each round. The numbers make it easier for group members to get started.
- Explain how the activity works. Presenter poses the question about evaluation use for conversation. Check for understanding of what people are to do one last time before beginning. Each group begins with the Interviewee discussing his/her thoughts and experiences on the topic for 2-3 minutes. The Interviewer prompts with additional clarifying questions as needed and the Recorder writes down the main ideas being discussed. Post in the front of the room how group members should switch roles for next round (or hand out sample rotation slips to each group). At the end of the first round, members in each group switch roles and repeat the process. At the end of the second round, group members assume their third and final role and repeat.

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- Call the group back together and provide final group instructions (found on the bottom of the participant handout). Allow 2-4 minutes for groups to discuss the commonalities and differences in their interview content.
- Bring the group together again. Ask each group to report one idea from the final list. If possible, record participants' thoughts on screen or on flipcharts to refer to later.

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Slide 6



Note to the presenter:
When the activity concludes, remind participants that you will tailor some of your comments to their ideas from this activity. (See slide 38).

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Slide 7



To the audience:
To be clear, this research was designed to look at use and involvement in multi-site evaluations, rather than studying the actual conduct of an evaluation.

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Slide 8



To the audience:
When people talk about UFE, the notion of intended use by intended users sets the stage. This research did not look at that issue because in the 4 programs we studied, the intended user was NSF, and that was not our research focus.

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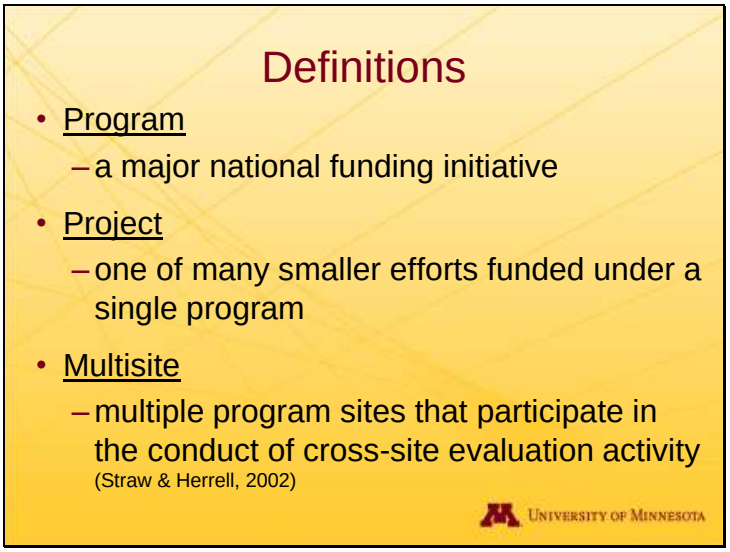
Slide 9



To the audience:
What this project did was to look at the use by a secondary or "unintended" user, often those who were in the target market for program dissemination efforts. More specifically, this study examined STEM (science, technology, education and math) education programs all funded by the National Science Foundation. Inherent in NSF funding is the notion that projects disseminate findings and lessons learned to help other projects improve their efforts. In addition to studying the effects of involvement on use by the project staff in the 4 large multisite programs, we also examined the idea of use in the broader field of evaluation and STEM education; that information will not be part of this presentation.

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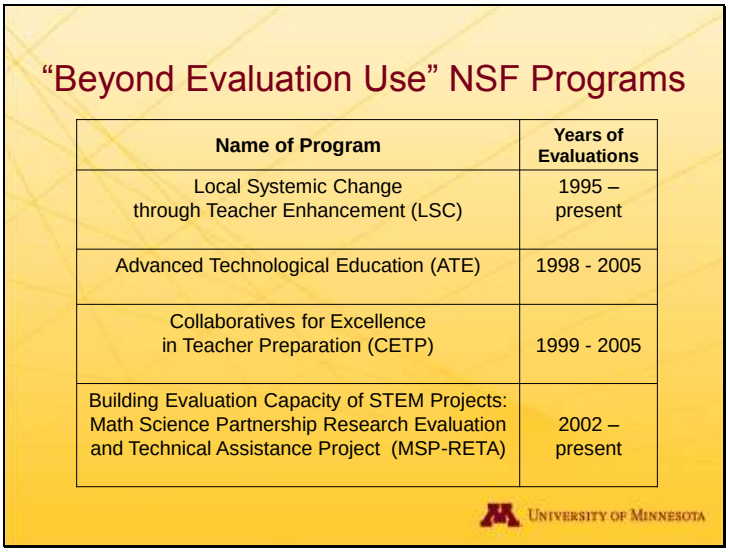
Slide 10



Note to the presenter: These terms help set the framework for implications/findings later on in the presentation.

To the audience:
Regarding this idea of multisite, it is important to know that we are talking about a large program that offered funds to local projects that worked toward the program goal. In turn, each local project might target a slightly different audience and use different activities to work toward the shared program goal. Thus, these were not model programs implemented in identical ways at multiple sites.

Slide 11

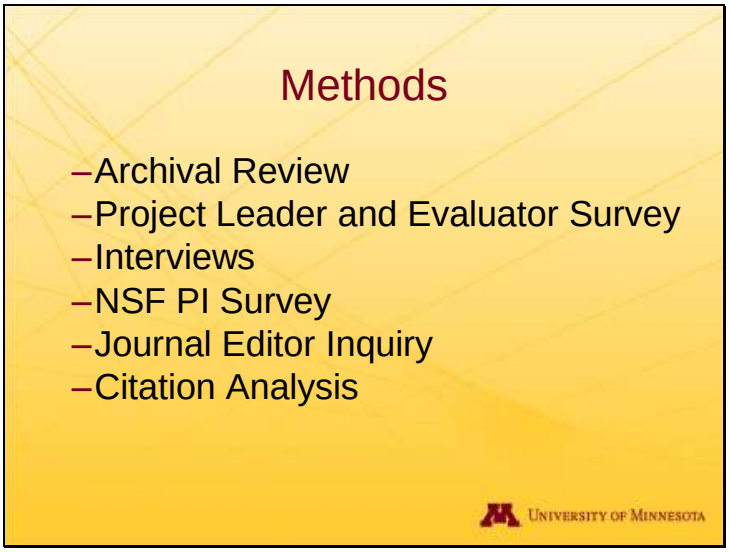


Note to the presenter:
There is a program description summary handout in the Presenter's Toolkit that may help set the context. The audience sometimes needs help to understand the scope of this research.

To the audience:
These four programs are funding streams from NSF that all had large program evaluations. This research looked at the evaluations of the overarching programs, not at the project evaluations done by local projects within the 4 programs listed here.

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Slide 12



To the audience:
Archival review – hundreds of reports, other documents, and websites were reviewed
Survey – of Project PIs and evaluators in the 4 programs
Interviews of survey respondents and NSF program officers
Survey of a random sample of current NSF Education Directorate PIs asking about their familiarity with the evaluations
Journal editor inquiry – e-mails and calls to several science and math education and evaluation journal editors asking about publications related to the evaluations
Citation analysis - Bibliographic research looking for evidence of the program evaluations in others' published work.

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Slide 13



To the presenter:
Here are supporting points for these items:

•There are many terms in the field (use, influence, participation, involvement), and people have different ideas of what they mean. Although we tried to control for this by telling participants what we meant, it became clear that in some cases respondents were not always talking about the idea we intended.

- The study occurred at a single time often years after the projects ended, so some respondents had difficulty recalling specifics of their experience (sometimes exacerbated because many times the same people served on a number of projects).

- Respondents to the surveys did not always respond in terms of the overall program evaluation, but rather provided answers related to a local project evaluation within that larger program.

4. There was great variety in the large programs, making identification of all project Pis a challenge and likely leading to non-response.

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Slide 14



•Money is seldom set aside to study evaluation so this research was a rare chance to look at the idea of participation and use in large multisite evaluations to advance knowledge in the field.

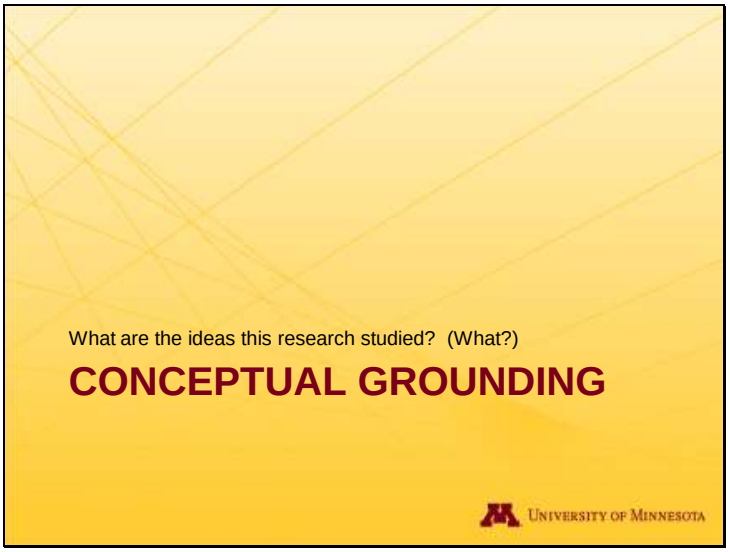
• This was not a simulation study…these are real world programs doing real program evaluations, therefore this study is unlike most that have been conducted.

• We were able to examine influence beyond the primary intended user (NSF) and look at use by the projects and the field, a new area of research.

• This research used a variety of methods to examine this idea along with the development of a number of instruments.

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Slide 15

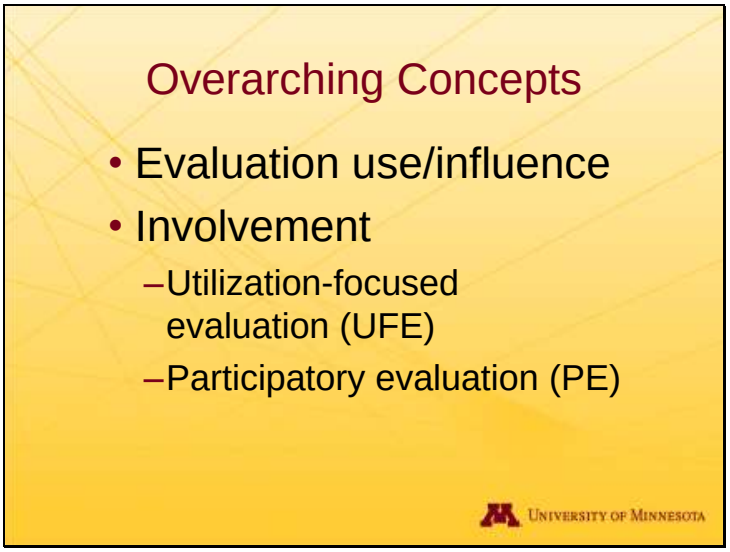


Note to the presenter:
The next 15 slides provide an overview of the two major concepts that grounded the research: evaluation use/influence, and involvement. If your audience is primarily interested in the practical implications of the study, you may want to skip the entire section and move to the slides on multi-site evaluation (starting with slide 31). Even in this case, however, you may want to show slide 16 (the next slide) so that people are at least aware of the overarching concepts.

To the audience:
We want you to be sure of the evaluation ideas that grounded this research…

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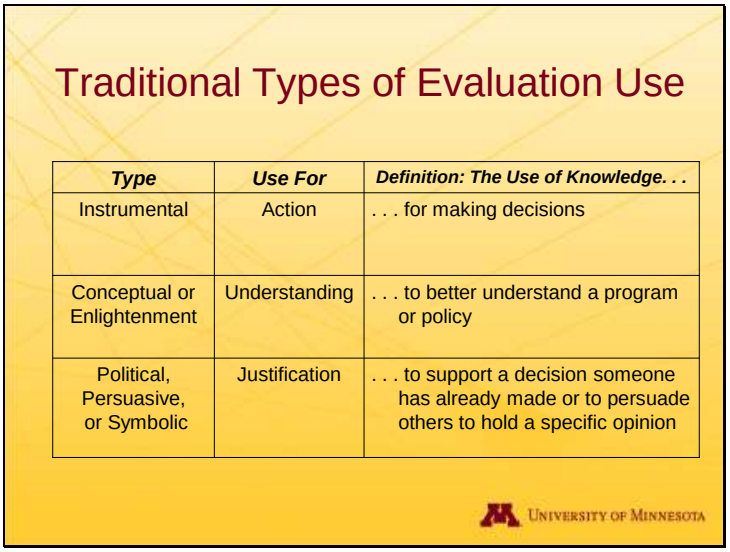
Slide 16



Note to the presenter:
This is the general overview of the two major ideas that grounded the research.

To the audience:
• Two overarching concepts guided the research project.
• We used the terms evaluation use and evaluation utilization interchangeably.
• Karen Kirkhart added the concept of influence to the literature in 2000.
• The second overarching concept evolved during the study. We began with two ideas: UFE, and PE. The central point of utilization-focused evaluation involves "primary intended use(s) by primary intended users." But this emphasizes primary and intention, which were not, finally, what we were studying. Nevertheless, it was important to understand the concept because of its centrality to use.
• We also began with the concept of participatory evaluation since we were interested in looking at the extent to which engaging project-level staff in the program evaluations had an effect on eventual use or influence.

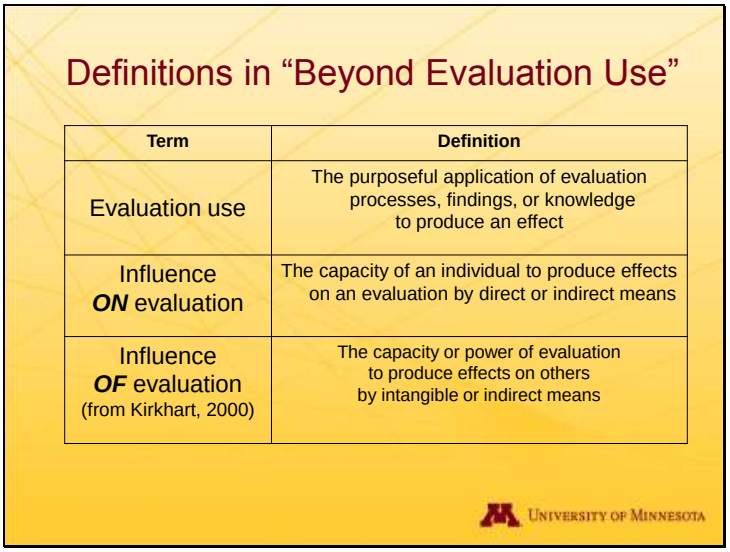
Slide 17



Note to the presenter:
Type is the most important column because these are the terms with which people may be familiar. The Use For column provides a short-hand summary of the definitions.

To the audience:
• In the research on evaluation use, conducted since the 1970s, there are three common labels.
• The first is instrumental use, which is what many evaluators hope to see as a result of their work. Initially, research suggested that instrumental use was not as common as was desired.
• The second type of use is called conceptual use or enlightenment, which is Carol Weiss's term. People may gain insights or knowledge as a result of an evaluation, even if they never apply its results directly.
• The third type of use goes by several names (political, persuasive, symbolic) and holds the potential for bias. In this type of use, people use an evaluation's results for personal reasons.

Slide 18

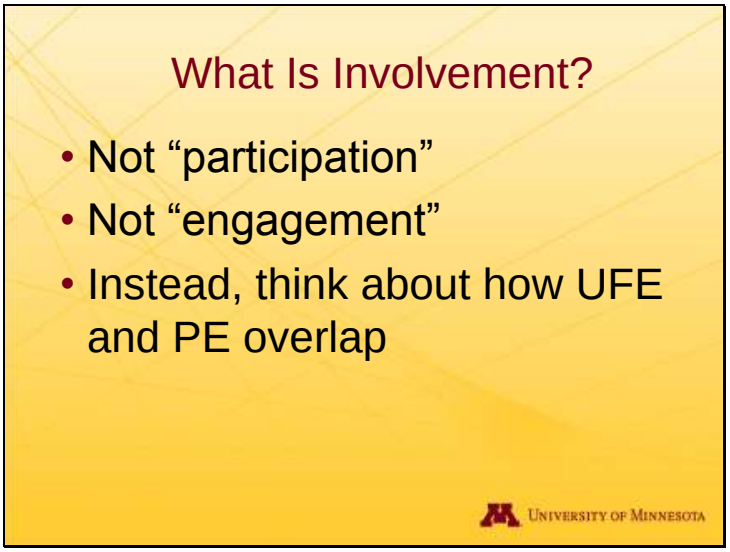


Note to the presenter:
You may not want to go over these in detail, but they are provided for clarity.

To the audience:
• These are the definitions that were used in the research.
• Evaluation use is purposeful and seeks to create an effect.
• "Influence on" is at the heart of participatory evaluation, whereby people engage actively in the evaluation process and change it (i.e., produce effects) as a result.
• "Influence of" broadens the idea of purpose or active use to consider the potential intangible or indirect effects of evaluations.

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Slide 19

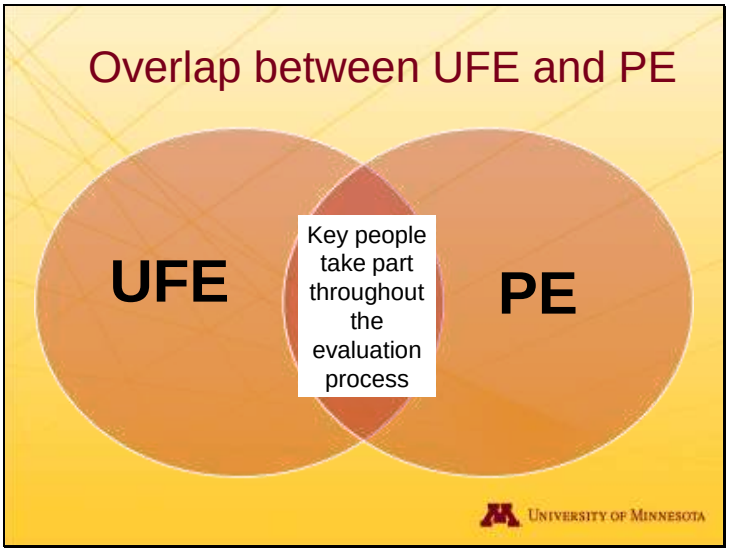


Note to the presenter:
Audiences often ask why we used the term involvement, and this slide explains why.

To the audience:
• Participation is often considered in a local context. You can imagine people sitting around a table together, working side-by-side and discussing the evaluation. In multi-site evaluations, that is usually not possible (e.g., people are geographically dispersed, or there are too many sites).
• Engagement suggests an active role in planning or implementing evaluation activities. That is different than the role played by many of the people in the projects we studied. Because they did not play an active role in designing the program evaluation in which their project took part, they were not truly “engaged.”
• In thinking about project staff activities in the program evaluation, we decided to think about the overlap between UFE and PE.

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Slide 20

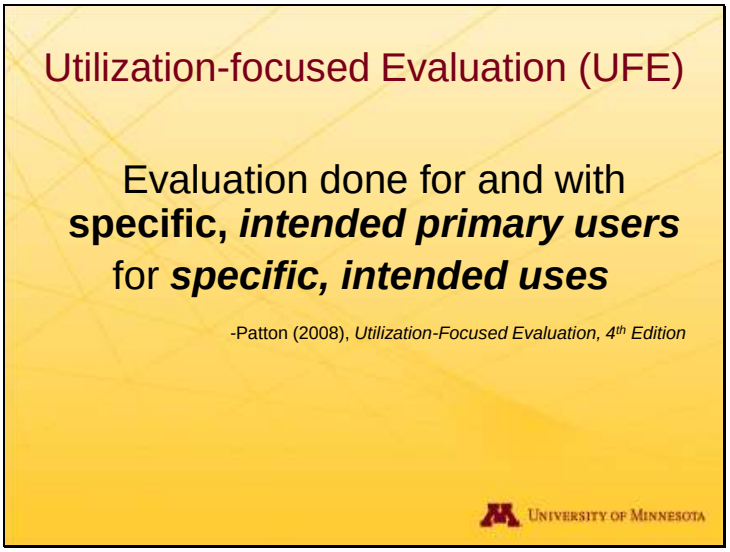


Note to the presenter:
This Venn diagram appears four times (slide 20, slide 24, slide 30, and slide 34).
Each time, a different idea, which you may want to emphasize, is presented. Here we emphasize the common content in the overlap.

To the audience:
• Here is a graphic representation of the overlap between UFE and PE.
• The common idea in the highlighted area is that key people take part throughout the evaluation process.
• In UFE, these key people are the primary intended users.
• In PE, these key people are the participants who actively engage in planning and conducting the evaluation.

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Slide 21



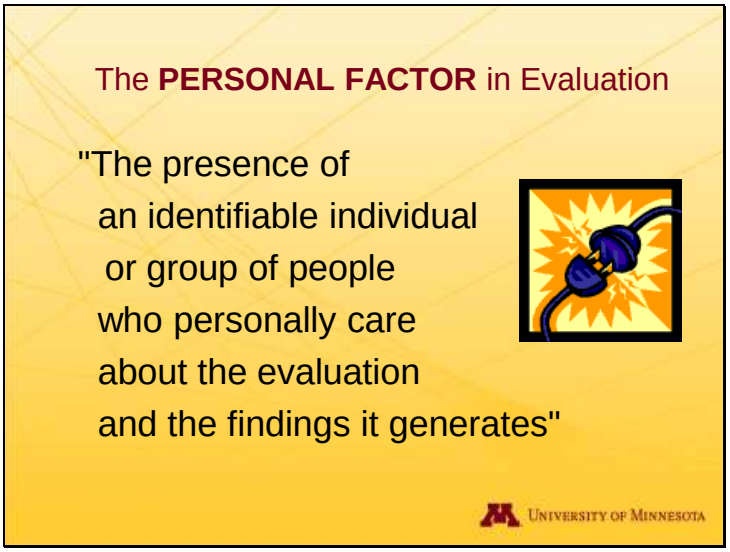
To the audience:

• This is the formal definition of utilization-focused evaluation, taken from the most recent edition of Michael Quinn Patton's book of the same name.

• Note that it emphasizes both the people who will use the evaluation and what they will actually do with the evaluation.

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Slide 22

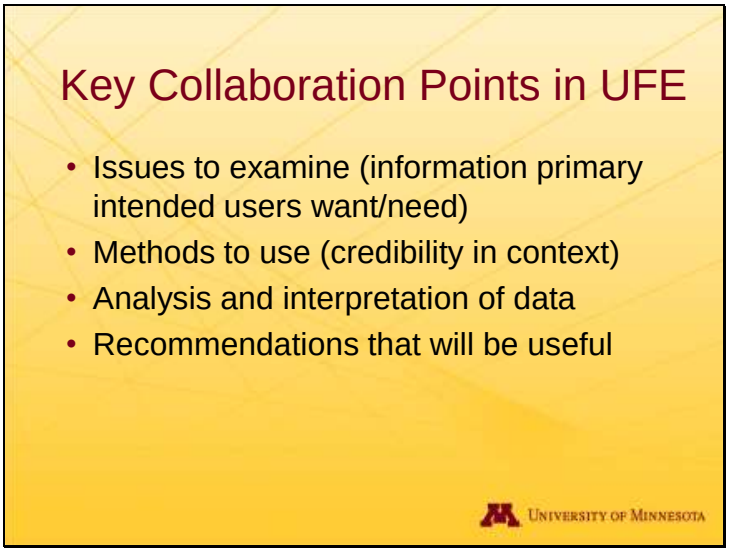


Note to the presenter:
You may want to explain the plug graphic, the idea that an individual or group can actively create energy around an evaluation process or its findings.

To the audience:
• The personal factor, which came out of a research study conducted in the late 1970s, is another of Patton's central ideas.
• The point is straightforward: When the person or people who care about an evaluation are involved in its process, then good things, including use, are likely to happen.
• The opposite is also true: If people are not engaged in an evaluation, then the likelihood of eventual use decreases.

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Slide 23

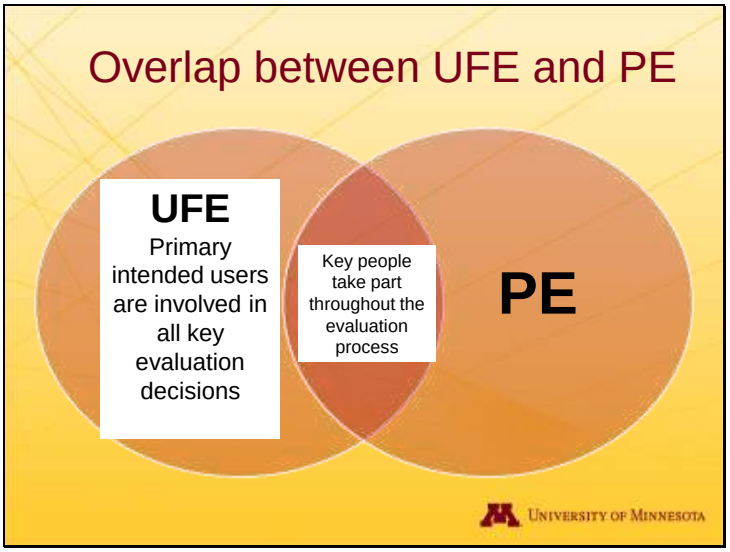


Note to the presenter:
People may not know the four points where interaction with primary intended users is critical. They are listed here.

To the audience:
• UFE provides opportunity for the primary intended users to collaborate throughout the entire evaluation process.
• According to Patton, there are four specific points where the evaluator and primary intended users need to connect: first, during the framing of the evaluation; second, during the identification of data-collection methods; third, during the analysis and interpretation of the data; and finally, during the recommendation development stage.
• If evaluators interact effectively with primary intended users at these four points, the evaluation's results will answer the primary intended users' questions and the likelihood of use will be increased.

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Slide 24

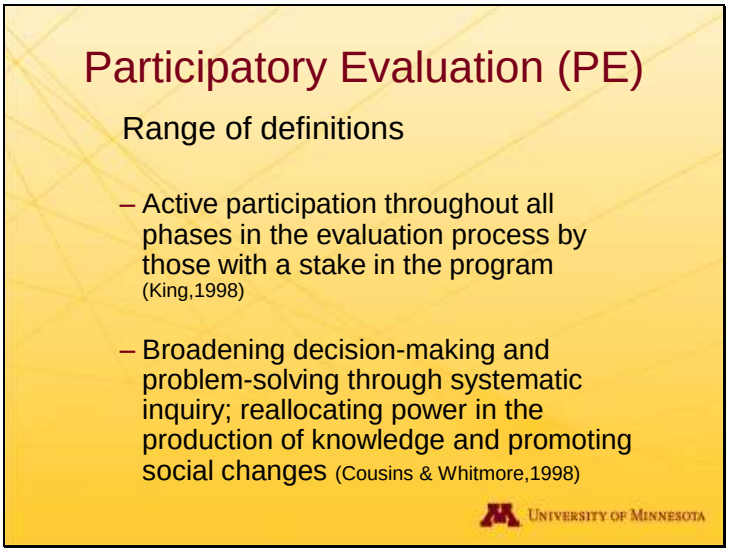


Note to the presenter:
This is the second time this Venn diagram occurs, and this time it emphasizes the key characteristic of UFE.

To the audience:
To summarize, in UFE, primary intended users interact with the evaluator throughout the evaluation and are involved in all important decisions related to the evaluation.

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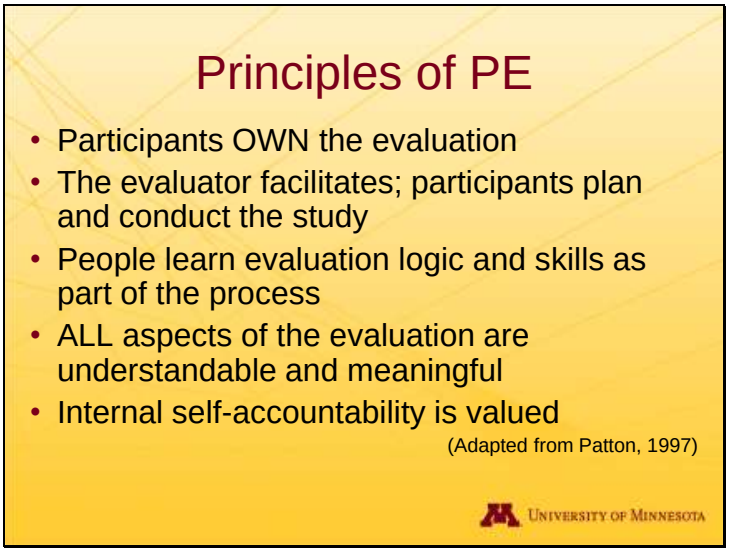
Slide 25



Note to the presenter:
UFE was the first overarching concept. Participatory evaluation (PE) is the second.

To the audience:
• PE is a broad concept with multiple meanings; people mean different things when they talk about participatory evaluation.
• The definitions of participatory evaluation range from the more pragmatic definition of King to the more transformative definition of Cousins and Whitmore.

Slide 26

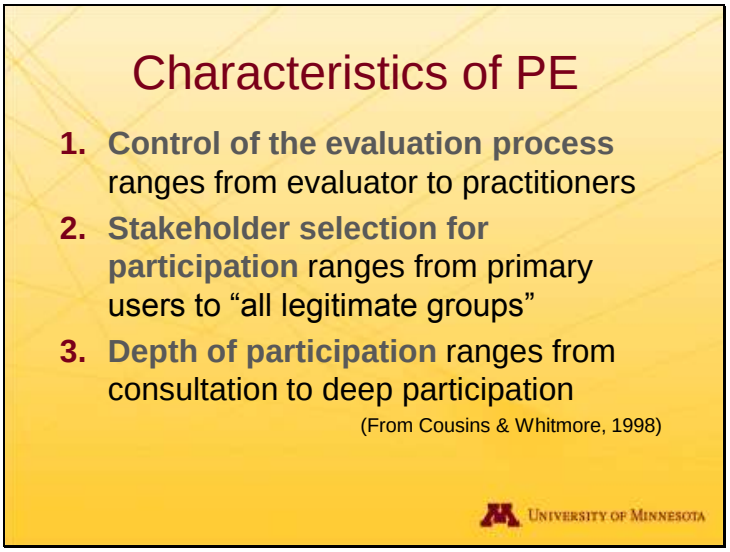


To the audience:

- The principles of PE relate to:
    - Active participant ownership of the evaluation and its processes;
    - The roles played by the evaluator (facilitator) and by evaluation participants (program staff, clients, or community members who actually plan and implement the study);
    - What people learn as a result of participating (i.e., evaluation logic and skills);
    - The clarity of what happens during the evaluation; and
    - The importance of people being accountable for what happens during the evaluation.
- The five principles listed here distinguish participatory evaluation from other forms.

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Slide 27



Note to the presenter:
In this slide we list and describe the three dimensions of Cousins and Whitmore's 1998 framework. The next slide (slide 28) has the figure as it appeared in their seminal article. You may prefer to use the graphic version to discuss the dimensions.

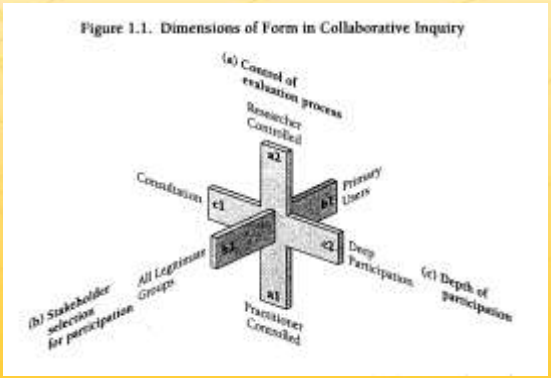
To the audience:

- Cousins and Whitmore published a framework in 1998 that identified three dimensions for analyzing collaborative inquiry like participatory evaluation.
- Each of the dimensions represents a continuum with the extremes indicated.
- The questions these dimensions ask are:
- Who controls the evaluation process? ranging from the evaluator to practitioners;
- Which stakeholders are selected to participate in the evaluation? ranging from primary intended users to everyone who has a right to participate;
- How deeply are participants involved? ranging from simple consultation to in-depth participation.

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Slide 28

Cousins & Whitmore Framework

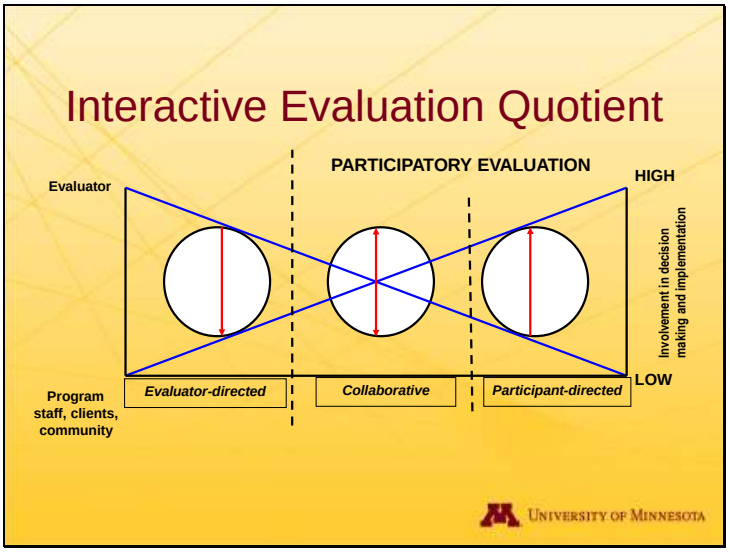


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To the audience:
This is one way to conceptualize and categorize participatory evaluation. You can take any participatory evaluation and plot it on this three-dimensional diagram with the characteristics we just outlined: control; depth of participation; and stakeholder selection.

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Slide 29

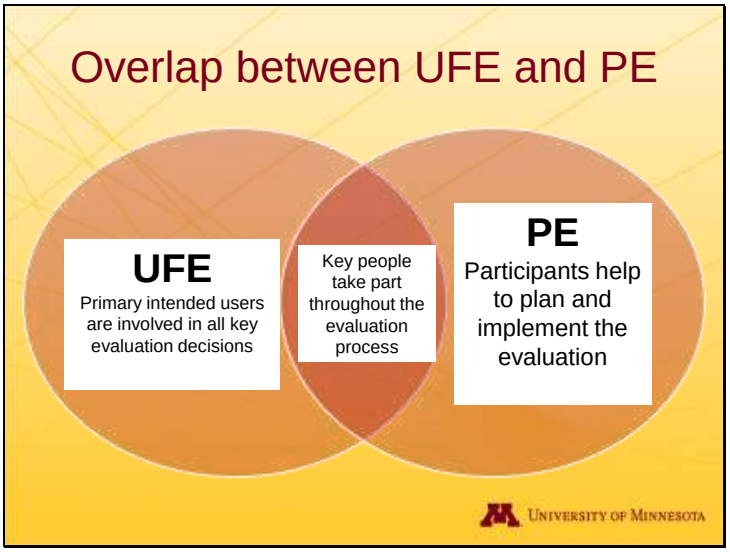


Notes to the presenter:
The interactive evaluation quotient is a diagram of the relation between the evaluator and participants in the evaluation (program staff, clients, community members).
Again, there is a continuum marked by two extremes: the evaluator completely in charge receiving input from the participants, or the participants completely in charge receiving coaching from the evaluator.

To the audience:
• Some find it easier to envision participatory evaluation using this diagram.
• Every evaluation needs to be planned (decision making) and conducted (implementation).
• You see that the two columns to the right symbolize two forms of PE: (1) collaborative, where evaluator and participants work together equally; and (2) participant-directed, where the evaluator plays a coaching role.
• The lines that cross in the middle show the potential range of roles and involvement of evaluators and participants in the evaluation process. There are many different ways for evaluators and participants to engage in the evaluation process.

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Slide 30

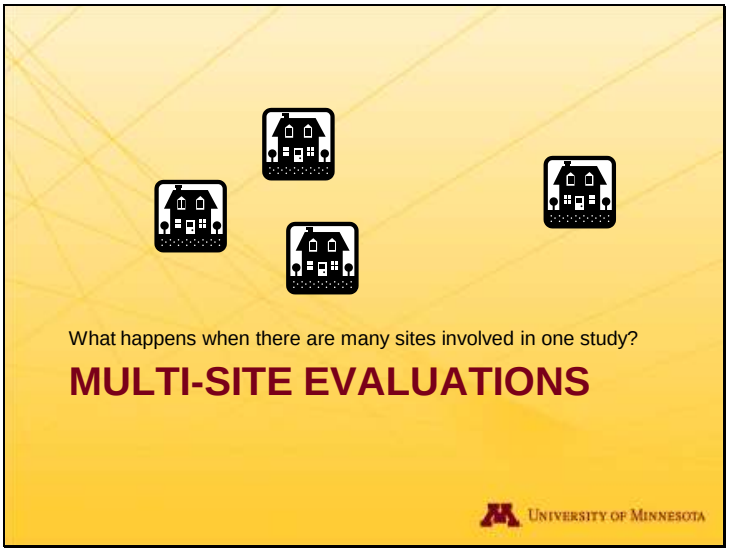


Note to the presenter:
This is the third appearance of the Venn diagram. This time the emphasis is on the content specific to participatory evaluation.

To the audience:
•To summarize, participants in a participatory evaluation are actively involved in planning and implementing the evaluation.
•These two ideas (UFE and PE), then, provide a means for examining evaluation use and participation when they are applied to a large, multisite setting.

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Slide 31

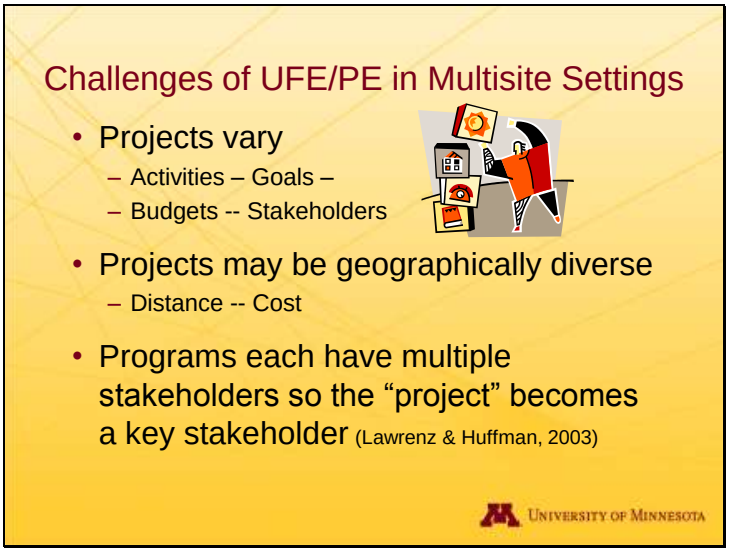


Note to the presenter:
The next slides (slides 31-34) describe the special features of multi-site evaluations.

To the audience:
Let's turn now to the special characteristics of evaluations that involve many different sites.

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Slide 32



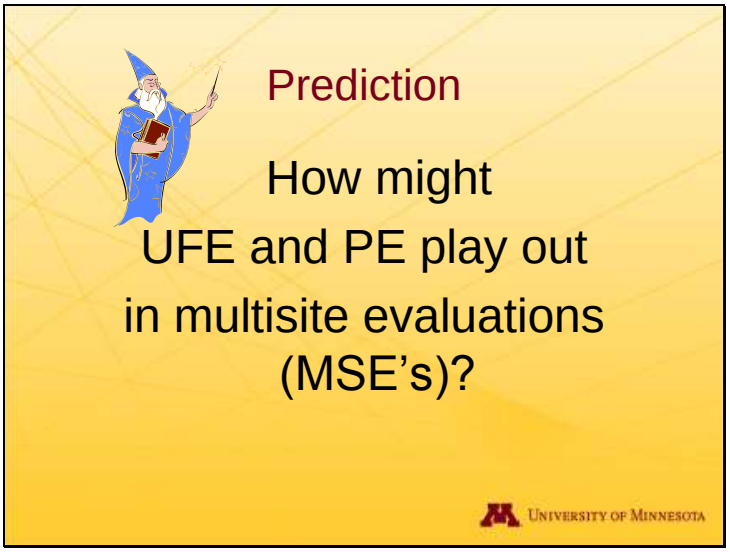
Note to the presenter:
The first two points on this slide are straightforward, but the third point may confuse the audience. The idea is that because multi-site settings are likely to include large numbers of stakeholders, the best way for the overarching program evaluation to proceed is by counting each project as a single stakeholder, not worrying about the multiple stakeholders who are part of the project's constituency.

To the audience:
• What happens when we take ideas from UFE and PE and apply them in a multi-site setting?
• Multiple challenges emerge:

- Projects vary – activities may vary, goals may vary, budgets are not equivalent, and many stakeholders exist for local projects and for the larger program.
- Projects' geographical diversity may create problems of distance, and it may become expensive to connect and encourage participation.
- Programs typically have a large and complex set of stakeholders. In large multi-site evaluations, each individual project becomes one key stakeholder, rather than having the multiple stakeholders within each project as program stakeholders.

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Slide 33

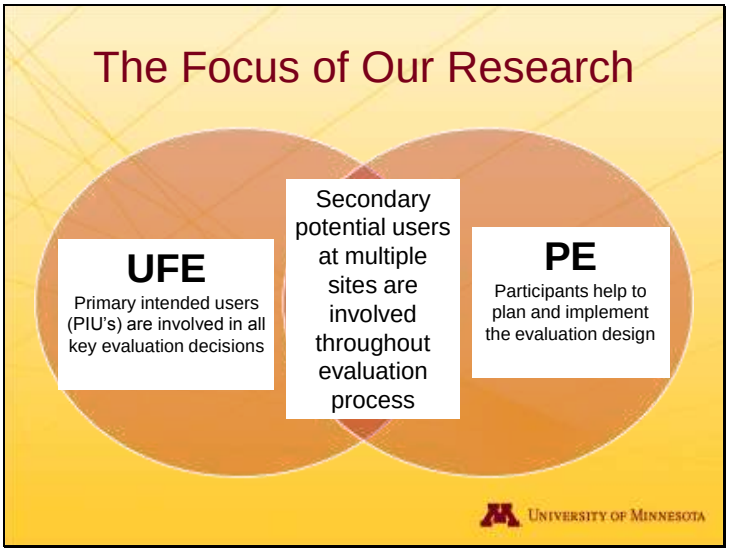


Note to the presenter:
Ask participants to call out predictions about how UFE and PE may differ in a multisite context, or have them turn to a neighbor to discuss possibilities before asking the group for ideas.

Examples:
- Different indicators of success across different stakeholders
- Sampling challenges
- Differences in implementation across sites
- The elusive common denominator across sites
- Different lifecycles across project implementations
- Dealing with multiple – multiples: complexity of multiple agencies in multiple places dealing with multiple problems that align with similar goals
- Feeling alienation from program evaluation but feeling ownership of the local project evaluation
- Challenges with aggregation of data across sites

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Slide 34



Note to the presenter:
This is the fourth time the Venn diagram has appeared. This time note that the content in the overlap is different from the first time, indicating what our research project studied.

To the audience:
• People (practitioners and researchers alike) often assume that the evaluation process for local projects will be the same as those for larger-scale multi-site evaluations, and we have found that this is not necessarily true.
• The focus of our multi-site research was on the overlap in this diagram: studying the secondary potential users who were involved in the program evaluation process at the various sites making up the multi-site evaluation.
• It differed from UFE because we studied the secondary users, rather than the primary.
• It differed from PE because these participants were not actively engaged in making program evaluation decisions.

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Note to the presenter:
Now we move to the results of the research.

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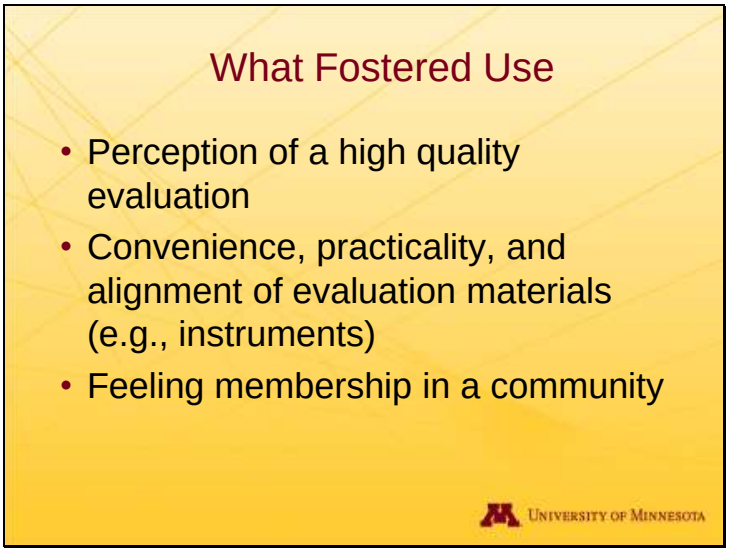
Slide 36



Note to the presenter:
This slide summarizes our results in the broadest terms. You may want to link these findings back to the comments participants made in either the prior prediction activity or in the three-step interview.

To the audience:
The research documented that these secondary potential users did sometimes feel involved in the larger program evaluation and did sometimes use its results. Three things fostered their feelings of involvement:
•Meetings (face-to-face) link back to Patton's idea of the personal factor.
•Making plans that intentionally address use smacks of both UFE and PE.
•Being asked to provide data made people feel involved in the evaluation process.

Slide 37



To the audience:

• Project staff were more likely to use the evaluation process and its results when they believed the multi-site evaluators had good reputations and when they felt that the evaluation used rigorous procedures.

• Not surprisingly, project staff were more likely to use evaluation materials that were practical and easily transferable to other settings and that fit their own perceived needs.

• Project staff were more likely to use materials that they felt had been developed by a professional community to which they belonged. Developing a feeling of a community of projects appeared to encourage project staff to use the evaluation processes and materials.

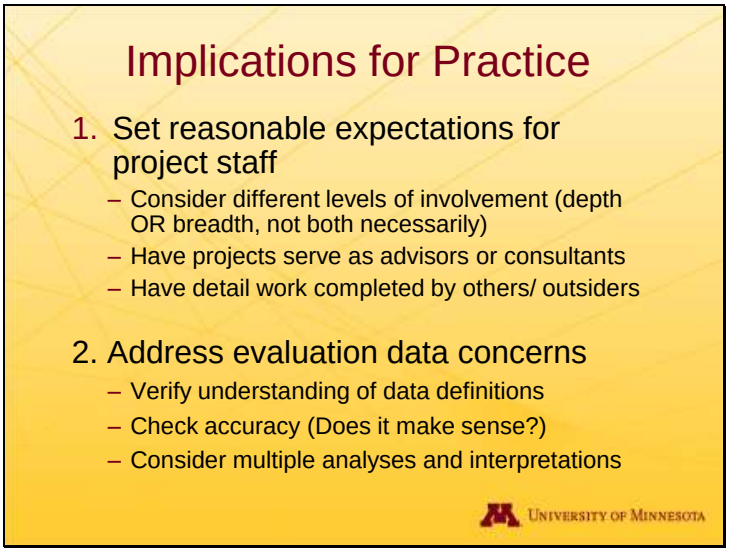
Slide 38



Note to the presenter:
This is another opportunity to revisit the results from the interview explicitly which may help the audience to better see how the implications slides relate to them.

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Slide 39



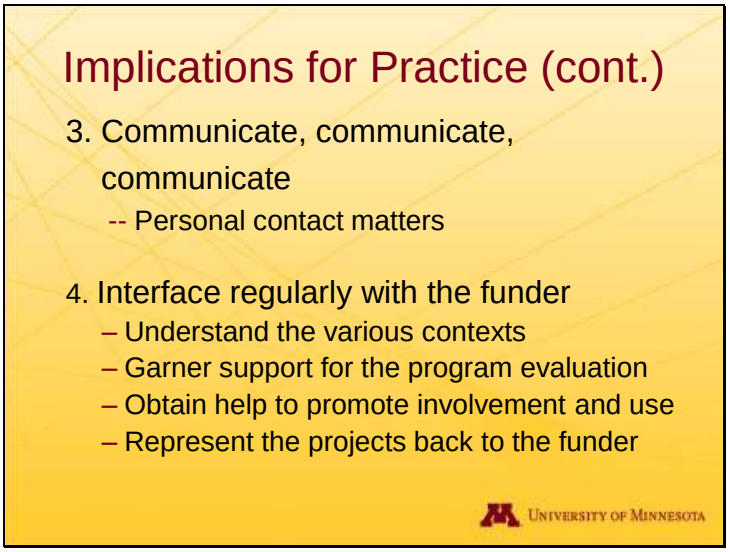
Note to the presenter:
The implications are fairly straightforward, and the examples provided will help people understand how they worked in the cases from our research. You may also want to ask people to generate examples from their own multi-site experiences.

Examples for implication #1:
•LSC had a small, select group of PIs help develop instruments and directions for scoring classroom observations.
•ATE had a special evaluation advisory committee of evaluation specialists to suggest how best to conduct the evaluation.
•CETP did all the detail work on developing items and formatting surveys after the projects suggested topics.

Examples for implication #2:
•ATE conducted site visits where the site visitors had the survey data and could verify that the data provided in the survey matched the reality of the site.
•LSC had electronic data input forms that required ratings and justifications. LSC staff went through all of the ratings and made sure the rating matched the justifications.
•CETP sent data out to the projects and asked what analyses they would recommend, allowing for multiple interpretations.

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Note to the presenter:

Examples for implication #3:
•MSP RETA PI made personal site visits to several projects.
•All four evaluations provided presentations at meetings that the project PIs attended.
•LSC and CETP held meetings focused specifically on the program evaluation.

Examples for implication #4:
•LSC program evaluators made regular trips to NSF every other month or so to meet with the group of NSF-assigned program managers.
•CETP evaluators interacted via the Internet with CETP project PIs and NSF CETP program managers to provide regular updates about evaluation progress.
•ATE evaluators organized regular conversations with NSF through a lead ATE program officer, which encouraged local communication among all the ATE program and program evaluation managers.

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Note to the presenter:

Examples for implication #5:
•ATE coped with new projects joining the program by having special face-to-face sessions at the yearly PI meetings where the evaluation was explained to new PIs.
•CETP developed a set of primary and secondary contacts for each project.
•MSP RETA provided individualized help to each project.

Examples for implication #6:
•CETP projects didn't want to have project staff gather core data because it took them away from the local evaluation and didn't represent the uniqueness of their projects, so the CETP evaluation offered incentives for participation and allowed local projects to add their own items to the core surveys.
•MSP RETA had difficulty providing free consulting services for projects because project staff didn't believe they had time to work with the consultants. As a result MSP RETA allowed the free consultants to also develop ongoing paid consultantships with the projects. This provided more continuous contact and more in-depth help.
•LSC projects felt the core evaluation took resources away from local evaluations and didn't represent the uniqueness of their projects, so the LSC evaluation lobbied with NSF to have the amount of money given to each project the same (since all had to do the same evaluation activities) rather than a percentage of the amount awarded.

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Note to the presenter:

Examples for implication #7:
•The PIs for all four of the evaluations were careful to not present themselves as if they had all of the answers, to listen carefully to the projects and to structure interactions that facilitated group interactions and self learning. In other words, knowledge and progress emerged from group consensus and discussion rather than from lectures.
•CETP maintained a list serve of all of the projects and posted content regularly.
•LSC held yearly meetings to discuss how to rate classroom observations and a strong espirit de corps was formed.

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Note to the presenter:
In the Presenter's toolkit, you will find several vignettes for participants to discuss. Ask participants to divide into small groups to read and discuss one or more vignettes. They should consider questions like the following: If they were an evaluator with this program, how might they involve people? How might they plan for use? What could they tweak to help the many projects feel a stake in the process? Participants can use the Making the Most of Multi-site evaluation Checklist in the Toolkit to structure their discussion.

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Note to the presenter:
Vignettes are included in the trainer packet of materials and summary slides are included in this PowerPoint presentation. Use all 4 if you have a large group, or select 1 or 2 if you have a smaller group (remember to use the summary slides only for the vignettes you have selected for use with your group). Depending on time constraints, all of the vignettes may be discussed as a large group afterward. For the discussion, assign attendees to groups of 3-5 and give them about 8 minutes to read through the short vignette assigned to their group, and then discuss how the lessons presented in this presentation could be used to improve the given situation.

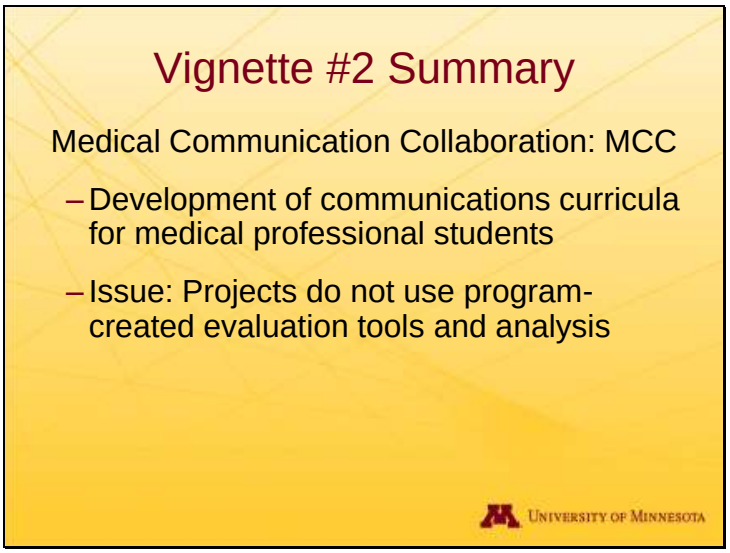
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Note to the presenter:
The following 4 summaries will help the groups that did not read a particular vignette to understand the issues up for discussion.

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Slide 47

Vignette #3 Summary

Professional Development for Districts: PDD

- Funding for professional development projects in primary education
- Issue: Local evaluators asked to provide program evaluation data one year after beginning project-level evaluation which took time away from the local evaluation

University of Minnesota

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Vignette #4 Summary

Foundation for Fostering Urban Renewal: FFUR

- Evaluation technical assistance and consultative services program launched by grantor to provide direct technical assistance to any of their grantees.
- Issue: Few grantees taking advantage of the assistance and consultation.

University of Minnesota

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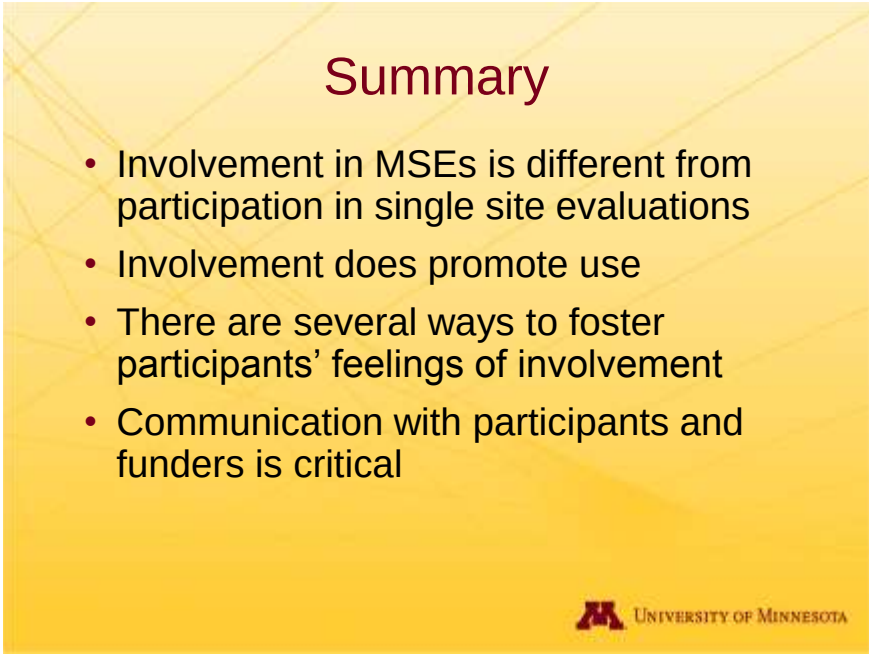


Note to the presenter:

This is the participants' chance to raise any questions they may have. You may want people to turn to a neighbor to discuss possible questions and then ask each pair or small group to raise one question they discussed.

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Slide 50



Note to the presenter:
These statements essentially speak for themselves.

To the audience:

- MSEs are often more complex than single site evaluations and require that mechanisms for management, communication, and trust building have to be explicit.
- Our survey and interview results indicated that being involved in an evaluation in some way did tend to increase use for unintended secondary users.
- It appears that almost any type of involvement will foster feelings of being involved, but promoting the development of a community appeared to lead to the most use.
- It will probably come as no surprise—and our data documented--that there can never be too much communication.

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To the audience:

- Here is contact information for the "Beyond Evaluation Use" research project.
- We welcome questions and comments.

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How can the program evaluators better foster involvement and use?

Vignette #1: HTTP		Vignette #2: MCC
The Health Technician Training Program (HTTP) is a national program designed to increase the number of health care technicians in the United States. Funded projects work with health care providers and vocational technical colleges to create specific training programs in medical technology and recruitment of instructors and students. There are 250 projects nationwide funded for a minimum of three years at $350,000 per year. The program evaluation consists primarily of an annual online survey of projects with general questions relating to number of activities, participants, and other questions related program outcomes. In an effort to gather information that speaks to the program goals, the program evaluators needed to ask general broad questions. However, the projects, which were often tailored to local efforts in a specific field within health care technology often complained that the questions, and consequently the information yielded from the report, did not apply to the projects.		Medical Communication Collaboration (MCC) is a national program aimed at research universities with medical professional training programs and departments of communication. Funded projects are charged with developing curricula for medical professional students related to both interpersonal and intercultural communication. Thirty projects were funded for three years at $150,000 per year. One year into the program, during an annual meeting of all the project leaders, participants suggested that they could use help with evaluation. As a result, a program level evaluation was funded to help projects with evaluation by providing evaluation tools and analysis. Projects were asked to collect data using a prescribed format and to send their data to the program evaluator. The program evaluator would then return the data to the project in a user-friendly format so that projects could conduct their own analysis. In the end, despite their initial interest in having an overarching program evaluation, the projects only participated to a limited degree with the program evaluation.

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How can the program evaluators better foster involvement and use?

Vignette #3: PDD		Vignette #4: FFUR
A Department of Education program called Professional Development for Districts (PDD) was created to give school districts in the Midwest funding for professional development projects in primary education. Seventy-five districts secured $200,000 each for two years for professional development projects on a variety of topics including math teaching skills, sexual harassment, diversity, and science education. Projects were required to have a local evaluation and were told one year into the project that those local evaluators also needed to supply data for the program evaluation. Consequently, project evaluators had to allocate time and resources for the program evaluation, which detracted from their local evaluations. Although data related to the program evaluation was reported back to the projects, projects wanted data directly related to local students and schools.		The Foundation for Fostering Urban Renewal (FFUR) launched a new evaluation technical assistance and consultative services program in order to better serve its 100 grantees who often struggled with the evaluation requirements of their grants. Grantees represented urban social service and education programs across the Midwest who received grants ranging from $5,000 to $100,000 for community-based revitalization programs in the areas of housing, health, education, crime prevention and others. The evaluation services program was committed to providing direct technical assistance to any of their grantees in the areas of identifying evaluation needs, developing program evaluation models based on those needs, and building evaluation capacity within those projects. Further, this program offered technical assistance and expert consultation via a network of evaluation consultants. The program worked toward these goals by offering educational seminars, conferences, materials, and individualized technical assistance related to evaluation to any grantee who requested assistance. One year into the program, only eight grantees had requested the assistance or services of the program.

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ADVANCED TECHNOLOGICAL EDUCATION (ATE) PROGRAM

ATE PROGRAM DESCRIPTION

Program Period: 1993-2005

Target: Primarily students and teachers in 2-year colleges and collaborating institutions. Also secondary students and teachers, as well as 4-year post-secondary.

Sites Funded: 345 sites were funded, of which 200 were 2-year colleges; secondary schools, 4-year colleges, and associations.

Program Budget: Approximately $350 million

Program Purpose: To increase U.S. productivity and international competitiveness by (1) building capacity to provide advanced technological education in high technology fields, and (2) increasing the number and skill of advanced technicians. Aimed primarily at 2-year colleges, but also included 4-yearcolleges and secondary schools.

ATE CORE EVALUATION DESCRIPTION

ATE CORE EVALUATION QUICK FACTS

Period: 1999-2005

Budget: $3.1 million

Principal Investigator: Arlen Gullickson, PhD., Professor Emeritus, Evaluation Center at Western Michigan University

CORE EVALUATION PURPOSE

The purpose of the ATE core evaluation was to measure the activities, accomplishments, and effectiveness of ATE projects and centers for general accountability purposes. To collect data on the underlying drivers of program success including collaboration with partners, professional development, and project sustainability.

CORE EVALUATION DESIGN

The evaluation design included mixed methods and featured a quantitative annual web-based survey and multiple site visits where primarily qualitative information was gathered. The surveys collected annual data on the activities and accomplishments and site visits collected data on collaboration with partners, professional development, and project sustainability.

CORE EVALUATION QUESTIONS

- To what degree is the program achieving its goals?
- Is it making an impact and reaching the individuals and groups intended?
- How effective is it when it reaches its constituents?
- Are there ways the program can be significantly improved?

CORE EVALUATION ACTIVITIES

Principal evaluation activities included:

- Convened meetings of ATE Advisory Committee
- Fielded annual grantee survey 2000-2005
- Conducted 13 site visits – reports given only to sites
- Commissioned 9 issue papers – synthesizing site visit findings and survey results
- Developed four targeted studies (on value-added to business/industry, materials development, professional development, and sustainability.)
- Four meta-evaluations were conducted.

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COLLABORATIVES FOR EXCELLENCE IN TEACHER PREPARATION (CETP) PROGRAM

CETP PROGRAM DESCRIPTION	
	Program Period: 1993 – 2000 (last year new projects were funded) **Target Population:** Prospective preK-12 teachers **Program Budget:** $350 million **Site Funds:** 25 Response to the national need to produce and retain increasing numbers of well-qualified teachers of mathematics and science. **Program Purpose**: To achieve significant and systemic improvement in the science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) preparation of prospective pre-Kindergarten through grade 12 (preK-12) teachers.
CETP CORE EVALUATION DESCRIPTION	
CORE EVALUATION QUICK FACTS	**Period:** 1999 – 2004 **Budget:** $999,000 **Principal Investigator:** Frances Lawrenz, Ph.D., Associate Vice President for Research and Professor of Educational Psychology, University of Minnesota
CORE EVALUATION PURPOSE	The purpose of the CETP core evaluation was to learn to what extent the CETPs succeeded in achieving significant and systemic improvement in the science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) preparation of prospective pre-Kindergarten through grade 12 (preK-12) teachers.
CORE EVALUATION DESIGN	The overall design was mixed methods. Methods used included surveys (dean/department chair survey, PI/evaluator survey, pre- and post- faculty survey, college student survey, grades six to twelve student survey, K-12 teacher survey, principal survey, NSF scholars' surveys), classroom activities assessment rubric, and classroom observations. Although standardized instruments were developed, sites were free to use their own evaluation instruments or they could add items to the standard instrument. As the sites were not required to participate in the evaluation, data were not collected from all sites.
CORE EVALUATION QUESTIONS	- *To what extent did the CETP program impact the collaboration and focus of university faculty on instructional issues?* - *To what extent did the CETP program impact the instructional techniques used by university faculty?* - *Did K-12 teachers who participated in CETP projects view their preparation programs differently from teachers who participated in other preparation programs?* - *Were the instructional practices exhibited by K-12 teachers who participated in CETP projects different from the instructional practices exhibited by teachers who participated in other preparation programs?*
CORE EVALUATION ACTIVITIES	Convened meetings with CETP project personnel. - Developed data collection instruments (surveys, classroom observation protocols.) - Provided technical assistance to local CETPs for data collection and analysis. - Standardized instruments were developed, but sites were free to use their own evaluation instruments or could add items to the standard instrument. - As the sites were not required to participate in the evaluation, data were not collected from all sites.

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LOCAL SYSTEMIC CHANGE (LSC) THROUGH TEACHER ENHANCEMENT PROGRAM

LSC PROGRAM DESCRIPTION	
	Program Period: 1995 – 2005 **Program Budget:** $250 million in the 10-year period **Target Population:** K-12 teachers of science and mathematics; focus on entire school systems or districts, not on individual teachers **Sites Funded**: 88 projects current and completed projects across 31 states, and involving 70,000 teachers, 4,000 schools, 467 school districts, and 2,142,000 students. **Program Purpose**: To enhance teachers' content and pedagogical knowledge and their capacity to use instructional materials. LSC requires that the professional development is delivered to all teachers in a system (building- or district-wide) not to individual teachers. The ultimate goal is improved student achievement in math and science.
LSC CORE EVALUATION DESCRIPTION	
CORE EVALUATION QUICK FACTS	**Period**: 1995 – 2005 **Budget**: $6.25 million **Principal Investigator**: Iris Weiss, Ph.D., President, Horizon Research, Inc.
CORE EVALUATION PURPOSE	The purpose of the LSC evaluation was two-fold: 1. To provide information that could be aggregated across projects, to enable NSF to report on progress to Congress and to make mid-course adjustments to the program; and 2. To assess individual projects and to provide for appropriate mid-course adjustments.
CORE EVALUATION DESIGN	A cross-project "core" evaluation system used a mixed-methods design, with mandatory participation by 88 local projects nationwide. The core evaluation allowed local evaluators to assess their own projects, but also allowed for aggregate data across projects yielding broader insights about the design, quality, and impact of the program as a whole. Project evaluators collected data using standardized questionnaires and interviews, as well as observation protocols designed to answer core evaluation questions. Evaluators completed ratings on the quality of LSC professional development programs.
CORE EVALUATION QUESTIONS	- *What is the overall quality of the LSC professional development activities?* - *What is the extent of school and teacher involvement in LSC activities?* - *What is the impact of the LSC professional development on teacher preparedness, attitudes, and beliefs about science and mathematics teaching and learning?* - *What is the impact of the LSC professional development on classroom practices in science and mathematics?* - *To what extent are the school and district contexts becoming more supportive of the LSC vision for exemplary science and mathematics education?* - *What is the extent of institutionalization of LSC reforms?*
CORE EVALUATION ACTIVITIES	Overall, the LSC core evaluation logged observations of 2,400 professional development sessions and 1,620 mathematics or science lessons, the completion of 75,000 teacher questionnaires, 17,380 principal questionnaires, and 1,782 teacher interviews.

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MATH & SCIENCE PARTNERSHIPS – RESEARCH, EVALUATION, AND TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE (MSP-RETA) PROGRAM

MSP PROGRAM DESCRIPTION	
	Program Period: October 2002 - present **Program Budget**: ~ $460 million **Target Population**: Math and Science Educators K-12 and higher education **Sites Funded**: 77 projects in 30 states plus Puerto Rico, 550 school districts, 3300 schools, over 150 higher education institutions, and over 70 business partners. **Program Purpose**: Seeks to improve student outcomes in mathematics and science for all students, at all K-12 levels, and to significantly reduce achievement gaps in the mathematics and science performance of diverse student populations.
MSP-RETA DESCRIPTION	
EVALUATION QUICK FACTS	**Period**: October 2002 - 2007 **Budget**: $1.8 million **Principal Investigator**: Catherine Callow-Heusser, Project Director and Principal Investigator, Utah State University
EVALUATION PURPOSE	The purpose of the Utah State MSP-RETA was to provide technical assistance to MSP projects to identify evaluation needs and develop better program evaluation models.
EVALUATION ACTIVITIES	Provide curriculum development, professional development, career pathways and applied research on technician education through four project types: 1. Comprehensive Partnerships that implement change across the K-12 continuum in mathematics and/or science; 2. Targeted Partnerships that focus on a narrower grade range or disciplinary focus in mathematics and/or science; 3. Institute Partnerships: Teacher Institutes for the 21st Century that support the development of school-based teacher intellectual leaders; and 4. Research, Evaluation and Technical Assistance (RETA) projects that develop tools to assess the partnerships' progress and make their work more strategic, build evaluation capacity and conduct focused research.

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BEYOND EVALUATION USE

An Empirical Study of Involvement and Use/Influence in Multi-Site Evaluations

MAKING THE MOST OF MULTI-SITE EVALUATIONS CHECKLIST

IMPLICATION	TASK	TIMELINE	COMPLETED (Yes/No)
Set Reasonable Expectations	Decide on expected levels of project involvement		
	Solicit more advice than action by projects		
	Identify resources or personnel for detail work		
Address Data Concerns	Verify data definitions		
	Check accuracy		
	Consider multiple reviews of analysis		
Prioritize Communication	Identify evaluation stakeholders		
	Create a plan		
	Provide opportunities for feedback planning		
	Provide opportunities for feedback on implementation		
	Provide opportunity for feedback on analysis		
	Provide opportunities for input on report		
Interface with Funder	Study the context		
	Outline goals (stated and implicit)		
	Garner support for the evaluation		
	Integrate plans for use by funder and projects		
	Adopt the role of liaison between funder and projects		
Recognize Life Cycle	Identify intersection of evaluation and projects' life cycles		
	Identify at least two point people at each project		
Expect Tensions	Be aware of inter-project dynamics		
	Be aware of program-project dynamics		
	Be sensitive to resource constraints (e.g., time, money, personnel)		
Develop Community	Create face-to-face opportunities to interact		
	Maximize technology to allow for opportunities to interact		
	Disseminate information generously		
	Build credibility		

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Making the Most of Multisite Evaluations
American Evaluation Association Conference – November 12, 2009

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BEYOND EVALUATION USE

An Empirical Study of Involvement and Use/Influence in Multi-Site Evaluations

BEYOND EVALUATION USE

Voicing Variables Activity Instructions

It often helps to know something about your participants prior to beginning a training session. This activity is a brief introductory activity that allows you and the participants to get to know a little about one another's backgrounds and interests as they relate to multi-site evaluations.

Begin by asking participants to stand whenever they hear a description or characteristic that applies to them. When you and the participants have glanced around the room at those standing, you may instruct the group to sit. Next, ask participants to stand if the next trait applies to them. The traits you ask about are related to a broader theme or question and should be asked in an order that is easy for any participant to anticipate. Examples are provided on the following page. Feel free to modify the characteristics to suit your audience.

It is often helpful for the trainer to offer congratulatory or encouraging comments to participants as they stand, especially for some characteristics. For example, when asking participants to stand *"…If this is your first time at this conference*," it sets a positive tone in the session to welcome these participants to the conference and ask others in the room to do so.

If you have questions or would like to see this activity demonstrated, you may watch the video of the Making the Most of Multi-site Evaluations workshop found at http://www.cehd.umn.edu/projects/beu/default.html

Example: Voicing Variables for Multi-site Workshop

Variable	Options
Where do you currently live?	• Twin Cities • MN • Midwest USA • Other parts of USA • Other North America • Other parts of the world
How many times have you attended this conference?	• This is my first time • Twice • Three times • Four or more times
How long have you been an evaluator?	• Less than a year • 1-3 years • 4-7 years • 8 or more years
What fields have you conducted evaluations in?	• Education • STEM education • Health • Social service • Government • Other (please say)
Have you ever participated in a large, government-funded evaluation study?	• Yes • No
How many multi-site evaluations have you participated in?	• None • 1-2 • 3-4 • Five or more
In the multi-site evaluations you participated in, what were the sites like?	• Sites were the same, implementing the same thing • Sites were different, implementing different programs
What was the number of sites in the largest multisite you participated in?	• Five or fewer • Six to 15 • Sixteen to 30 • More than 30

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Interview Response Sheet

Name	**<u>Interview Question</u>: Think of a time when people truly used an evaluation that you were part of.** • **Describe that evaluation.** • **What distinguished it from other evaluations you've participated in?**
Key Group Ideas: *Similarities? Common themes? Conclusions?*	

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The Three-Step Interview Technique

Cooperative Interviews

- ❑ **The interview topic should be…**
  - Relevant to the program evaluation
  - Useful for obtaining information
  - Meaningful and linked to the personal experiences of participants
  - Safe and non-threatening
  - Open ended, thought provoking, achievable
- ❑ **Provide sample interview questions**
  - What? Where? When? Why? How?
- ❑ **Group members rotate roles (groups of 2 or 3)**
  - Interviewer
  - Responder
  - Recorder… *WORDS and SYMBOLS*
- ❑ **Arrange materials and work space to strengthen positive interdependence**
  - One shared *Interview Response Sheet* per group
  - Group members seated around one table or knee to knee for close proximity
- ❑ **After the interview, each group interprets/ uses the interview information**
  - Similarities? Common themes? Predictions? Conclusions?
- ❑ **Group members process social interaction**
  - Inclusiveness… *all voices sought and heard*
  - Careful listening… *TRUSTWORTHINESS enhances TRUST*
- ❑ **Acknowledgment and appreciation**

BEYOND EVALUATION USE

Making the Most Out of Multi-Site Evaluations

Evaluation and Feedback Form

Please rate the extent to which these statements represent your judgment of the effectiveness of the workshop in meeting its objectives.	**Strongly Disagree**	**Disagree**	**Agree**	**Strongly Agree**
The workshop content helped me to understand the principles of utilization-focused evaluation.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The workshop content helped me to understand the principles of participatory evaluation.	☐	☐	☐	☐
As a result of attending the workshop, I understand more about how to use involvement to increase the impact of multi-site evaluations.	☐	☐	☐	☐
What I learned will help me to identify ways to help stakeholders feel involved in multi-site evaluations.	☐	☐	☐	☐
What I learned will help me to develop solutions to challenges related to multi-site evaluations.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The workshop helped me to apply these ideas to evaluation examples.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The information presented is relevant to my work.	☐	☐	☐	☐
What is the most useful thing you learned from this workshop?				
Comments/Suggestions?				